Easy to Catch a Liar, Hard to Clear an Honest One: Language Models Diagnosing a Corrupted Reward Channel from a Verified Record

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Abstract

An agent that learns from rewards has to trust whatever reports those rewards. When the reports suddenly change, either the world changed or the reporter broke. From the reports alone these are indistinguishable, and reinforcement learning theory shows that no amount of further experience separates them. The prescribed escape is richer data about the reporter itself. We ask whether a frozen language model, handed exactly that data, uses it.

We build a two-option game in which a payout swap and a lying reporter produce byte-identical histories. Then we add one verified record: an independent check of one round's real result, printed beside what the reporter said about that round. That single line settles the case. We ask three large models, from two families, to answer one question with one letter. Is the reporter honest or lying?

They catch a lying reporter almost perfectly. At the 70B class that holds in every condition we tried; the 32B model slips in one wording. They clear an honest reporter far less often, and how often depends on things that should not matter. Averaged over rounds, letters, and wordings, a 72B model calls an honest reporter a liar 38% of the time when nothing has changed at all, and 58% of the time when the payouts moved. A 70B model from a second family calls an honest reporter a liar 26% and 48% of the time. Read strictly, our own registered rules discount three of those four numbers: the two payouts-moved numbers, because on those prompts the models read a printed answer below our registered bar, and Llama's nothing-changed number, because there the record lowered a score that already had the answer printed. The 38% carries the claim. The failure is not one of reading, because in the situation where nothing changed the same models score 0.96 to 1.00 with the answer printed in the prompt. Which surface feature drives it differs by family. For the Qwen models it is which round the record names, and for Llama it is which letter stands for "honest." Adding the record to a prompt that already states the answer makes Llama *less* likely to give that answer. We pre-registered the central number, predicted it wrong, and report both.

1. The question

Suppose you are playing a simple game. There are two buttons. Exactly one pays a point each round. A scorekeeper tells you what each press paid. For four rounds one button pays and the other does not. Then the reports flip, so the button that was paying is reported as paying nothing and the other one as paying a point.

Two stories explain this. In the first, the buttons swapped and the scorekeeper is reporting truthfully. In the second, the buttons did not move and the scorekeeper began reporting the opposite of every result. Both stories predict the same reports, on every round, forever. Watching longer does not help. A report is the real result with the scorekeeper's honesty applied to it, and flipping either one flips the report in the same way.

This is not a puzzle we invented. Everitt et al. [2017] formalize it as reinforcement learning with a corrupted reward channel, where the agent sees a reward signal that may differ from the true reward, and they prove that without some assumption about what the corruption can look like, no strategy does better than guessing. The proof is our two stories: a swapped payout under an honest scorekeeper and an unchanged payout under a lying one produce the same reports, so no amount of play tells them apart. Their prescribed remedy is to give the agent richer data about the reward channel itself, so that systematic errors in the signal can be told apart from changes in what the signal measures.

We give a language model that richer data in its plainest form. We call it a **verified record**. It is an independent statement of what one round really paid, printed next to what the scorekeeper said about that same round. If the two agree, the scorekeeper was honest on that round, and since a scorekeeper that starts lying in this game lies on every round from then on, the scorekeeper is honest. If they disagree, the scorekeeper is lying. One line settles the case. The question is whether a frozen language model, given that line inside its prompt, reaches the answer.

Three findings. Large models catch a lying scorekeeper almost perfectly. They clear an honest scorekeeper much less often, and the size of that shortfall moves with features of the prompt that carry no information about the answer. And the two families of models we test are moved by different features. Everitt's remedy assumes the agent uses the richer data. We find that it uses it in one direction.

2. The game, and the one line that settles it

2.1 A worked example

The scorekeeper is called a source and has a number. The model is told the rules before it sees any history; Appendix A prints them all. Four of them matter here.

- Through round 4 the reports were accurate and the point values did not change.
- After round 4 the values of the two original options may have swapped, the source may have started reporting the opposite of every result, both, or neither.
- A source that starts lying keeps lying on every later round.
- A fresh pair of options may appear later with its own values. The fresh pair exists so that a second question, which of the two new options pays, can test whether the model uses its verdict about the source on a choice the record never touched (Section 3.4).

Here is one history, in the wording the model actually sees:

```
Round 1 - you chose M. Source 7 reported 1 point.
Round 2 - you chose W. Source 7 reported 0 points.
Round 3 - you chose M. Source 7 reported 1 point.
Round 4 - you chose W. Source 7 reported 0 points.
Round 5 - you chose M. Source 7 reported 0 points.
Round 6 - you chose W. Source 7 reported 1 point.
Round 7 - you chose C. Source 7 reported 1 point.
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Round 8 - you chose D. Source 7 reported 0 points.
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Rounds 7 and 8 are the fresh pair, C and D.

In rounds 1 to 4, M paid and W did not. In rounds 5 and 6 the reports reverse. Either the values swapped or Source 7 started lying. Now add the verified record, which sits above the log:

```
Verified records:
Round 5 - actual result: 0 points. Source 7 had reported 0 points.
```

Round 5 really paid 0. Source 7 said 0. Source 7 told the truth on round 5, so Source 7 is honest, so the values swapped. The model is asked:

```
Question: Since round 5, has Source 7 been reporting each result accurately,
or reporting the opposite of each actual result?
Reply K if accurately, Q if the opposite.
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The correct answer is K.

2.2 The four situations

The game has two hidden switches after round 4, whether the point values swapped and whether the source started lying. Crossing them gives four situations. We name them by what happened, and we use these names throughout:

- **nothing moved, honest.** No swap, truthful source.
- **points moved, honest.** The values swapped, truthful source. This is the situation the question was built for, because something real changed and the model has to say the messenger is not to blame.
- **nothing moved, lying.** No swap, the source reports the opposite of every result.
- **points moved, lying.** Both happened.

The four situations form two matched pairs. *Points moved, honest* and *nothing moved, lying* produce the same log, because in both the reports flip after round 4. Likewise *nothing moved, honest* and *points moved, lying* produce the same log, because in both the reports keep saying M pays. The generator renders each matched pair from the same visible history, and the test suite asserts that the two members are byte-identical up to the verified record. There is no wording, ordering, or label through which the hidden cause could leak, because the strings are the same.

The visible flip is a trap. Consider the rule "if the reports flipped, the source is lying; if they did not, it is honest." Table 1 runs that rule through the four situations.

Table 1. What the flip rule says in each situation, and whether it is right.

situation	reports flip?	flip rule says	right?
nothing moved, honest	no	honest	yes
points moved, honest	yes	lying	no
nothing moved, lying	yes	lying	yes
points moved, lying	no	honest	no

The rule is right in two situations and wrong in two, so it scores exactly 0.500 on a balanced design, and because each matched pair holds one right and one wrong, an overall accuracy cannot see it. Section 3.5 gives the control that does.

2.3 Why the record is the only tie-breaker

The record names one round and states its real result. Nothing else in the prompt distinguishes the members of a matched pair, so the record is necessary, and because a lying source lies on every round, one record is enough.

We call one scenario, with its own option letters and its own hidden switches, a **world**. Which round a world's record checks is fixed by the world rather than sampled, so half the worlds check round 5 and half check round 6. Across the whole set, the recorded value is 0 exactly as often as it is 1, in every situation, so a model cannot answer by reading the recorded number alone; it has to compare it with the report.

3. How we ask

3.1 One letter, no written reasoning

Every prompt ends with a question and an instruction to reply with a single letter. We read the model's next-token distribution, restrict it to the two answer letters, and take the larger. No sampling, no chain of thought, no temperature. This is deliberate. We are not measuring what the model can work out with a scratchpad; we are measuring the answer it gives in one step, with no room to reason on the page. It also makes the instrument exact, because every prompt has one right letter and every answer is one of two tokens.

The two answer letters are drawn from the pool of letters not used as option names in that world, and which of them means "honest" alternates across worlds, so a policy that always emits one letter scores 0.500.

3.2 Five versions of each history

Each history is asked five ways. The differences between them are the controls.

- **with record.** The history with the verified record. This is the measurement.
- **no record.** The same history with the record removed. Nothing in the prompt now separates the two members of a matched pair, so the correct answer is undefined and the model's answer measures its default, not its inference.
- **answer printed.** The history with a line stating outright what happened after round 4 ("the point values for the two original options were swapped. Source 7 did not begin reporting the opposite of each actual result."). No record. A model that fails here cannot read the task, and nothing else about it is interpretable. It is the reading floor for everything else, and no with-record number is read except beside it.
- **answer printed plus record.** The same disclosure with the record added. A model told the answer and shown the evidence should do at least as well as one that has to infer, so this version is the ceiling for the one above. A with-record score above it means something is leaking, and voids the run.
- **salience.** With record, plus one rules line saying that "across records of this kind, the point values swapped about as often as a source began reporting the opposite." The line is true of the generator and identical in every situation, so matched pairs stay byte-identical. The question it asks is simple: does reminding the model that the world can change make it clear an honest reporter more often?

3.3 Sixty-four worlds, four wordings, two questions

There are 64 worlds, numbered. Four things are balanced across the numbering so that no two of them line up: which of the two original options paid first, which round the record checks, which of the fresh pair the source favors, and which answer letter means "honest." Section 4.3 reports the one place where two of these lined up, and the fix.

Each world is rendered in four wordings: a terse log, meeting minutes, a narrated prose paragraph, and a sports-commentary register. They differ in every sentence and agree on every fact.

Each rendering is asked two questions, in two separate prompts. The first is the one above, whether the source is honest. The second asks which of the fresh pair pays; we call it the **fresh-pair question** and use it in Section 4.8.

Sixty-four worlds by four wordings by five versions by four situations by two questions is 10,240 prompts per model.

Every interval in this paper is a bootstrap over worlds, never over prompts. The four wordings and two questions of one world share a history, so resampling prompts would count one history up to eight times.

3.4 Why the second question is asked on the fresh pair

In the example, rounds 7 and 8 use the fresh pair C and D, the record checks round 5, a press of M, and the fresh-pair question asks about C and D. That gap is deliberate. If the record had checked a press of C, the record alone would say whether C pays and the model could answer without ever deciding whether the source is honest. With the record on an old option and the question on a new one, the only route from the evidence to the answer runs through the source's honesty. The honesty question itself does not need this. It matters because the two questions are asked on the same history in two separate prompts, and Section 4.8 pairs the answers.

3.5 Three rules fixed before the runs

We registered these before any model saw the 64-world prompts, and they are the only rules used to read the results.

1. A with-record score above its own answer-printed-plus-record score voids the run.
2. An answer-printed score below 0.90 means the model cannot read the task, and voids what rests on it. The registered wording did not say whether that accuracy is averaged over the four situations or taken in each situation on its own. Section 5 quotes the wording and reports both readings.
3. On the no-record prompts, we compare how often the model says "lying" when the reports flipped with how often it says so when they did not. If the difference exceeds 0.25, the model is running the flip heuristic, and every with-record number is reported against that heuristic rather than against chance.

Rule 3 fires for every large model here. So every with-record number below is read beside the model's agreement rate with the heuristic. A model that simply followed the heuristic would agree with it nearly every time and score 0.5.

3.6 Models and cost

Qwen2.5-32B-Instruct and Qwen2.5-72B-Instruct [Qwen Team, 2025]; Llama-3.1-70B-Instruct and Llama-3.1-8B-Instruct [Grattafiori et al., 2024]. All in 16-bit floating point, transformers 5.16.1, batch 8, on rented GPUs. A 256-prompt bridge between two GPU types reproduced 256 of 256 choices, so we treat the hardware as one instrument. The whole paper cost $13.19 in rented compute.

4. Results

4.1 The lying reporter is caught

When the record disagrees with the report, the large models say so. Across the two lying situations, the source question with the record scores 0.934 and 0.938 at Qwen 32B, 1.000 and 1.000 at Qwen 72B, and 0.996 and 0.996 at Llama 70B. This holds whether the record names round 5 or round 6 and whichever letter means "lying" (Appendix C, Table C1), and across the four wordings at the 70B class, at 1.000 for Qwen 72B and 0.984 or above for Llama (Table C2). The one exception is Qwen 32B on the narrated-prose wording, which drops to 0.734 and 0.750.

4.2 The honest reporter is cleared much less often

Table 2 gives the with-record accuracy in each situation, beside the answer-printed accuracy on the same histories.

Table 2. Accuracy on the source question, 64 worlds, four wordings, bootstrap intervals over worlds. Answer printed is the same history with the answer stated and no record; with record is the measurement.

model	situation	answer printed	with record
Qwen 32B	nothing moved, honest	1.000	0.844 [0.789, 0.895]
	points moved, honest	0.957	0.758 [0.707, 0.809]
	nothing moved, lying	1.000	0.934 [0.906, 0.961]
	points moved, lying	0.992	0.938 [0.910, 0.961]
Qwen 72B	nothing moved, honest	1.000	0.617 [0.520, 0.711]
	points moved, honest	0.887	0.418 [0.316, 0.523]
	nothing moved, lying	1.000	1.000 [1.000, 1.000]
	points moved, lying	1.000	1.000 [1.000, 1.000]
Llama 70B	nothing moved, honest	0.961	0.742 [0.660, 0.816]
	points moved, honest	0.742	0.523 [0.430, 0.617]
	nothing moved, lying	1.000	0.996 [0.988, 1.000]
	points moved, lying	0.980	0.996 [0.988, 1.000]

We call the difference between accuracy in the lying situations and accuracy in the honest ones the **honest-reporter penalty**. Paired over the same resampled worlds, it is +0.135 [+0.098, +0.174] at Qwen 32B, +0.482 [+0.406, +0.557] at Qwen 72B, and +0.363 [+0.287, +0.443] at Llama 70B. It is the paper's central contrast.

Two cells in Table 2 sit under an answer-printed score below 0.90, *points moved, honest* at Qwen 72B and at Llama 70B. Section 5 says which cells survive each reading of the rules and what claim rests on them.

The plainest case is *nothing moved, honest*. Nothing happened. The reports never flipped. The record agrees with the report. Every model reads the answer off the page when it is printed (0.961 to 1.000). Asked to infer it, the 72B calls the reporter a liar 38% of the time and Llama 26%.

The three penalties are ordered by parameter count. Three points from two families cannot carry that as a claim, and a four-point ladder within the Qwen family on an earlier prompt set was not monotone, so we make no claim about scale.

The flip-heuristic control (rule 3) fires for every large model, and Table 3 shows that the with-record answers are not the heuristic in disguise. If they were, they would agree with it almost every time. They agree with it about half the time while scoring well above half. The models are reading the record. They are reading it asymmetrically.

Table 3. The flip-heuristic control. The first two columns are how often the model says "lying" on no-record prompts, split by whether the reports visibly flipped. The last two are, on the with-record prompts, how often the model's answer agrees with the flip rule, and its accuracy.

model	says "lying", reports flipped	says "lying", no flip	agrees with flip rule	accuracy
Qwen 32B	0.688	0.355	0.521	0.868
Qwen 72B	1.000	0.188	0.550	0.759
Llama 70B	0.832	0.156	0.555	0.814

4.3 It is inference, not reading

A low honest-situation score could mean the model cannot read these particular prompts, or that it reads them and infers wrongly. The answer-printed score answers the first for the model as a whole. To answer it inside the honest situations we split them by which round the record checks, round 5 or round 6, and compare answer printed and with record within each half.

That split had a flaw, found before writing. In the 64 worlds as first built, the round a world checks and the letter that means "honest" were both set by whether the world's index is odd or even. So every world whose record named round 6 was also a world whose honest answer was the second letter, and a model that cared only about the round and a model that cared only about the letter would have produced the same numbers.

The repair was to regenerate the 64 worlds with the letter pairing reversed and score the with-record source prompts again on all three models. Call them the original worlds and the reversed worlds. Read together they cross round and letter exactly, with 128 prompts in each of the four combinations per situation. Section 4.4 uses both sets to say which factor moves which model. This section uses the original worlds, and its comparison, reading against inferring within the same worlds, holds whichever factor is at work.

Table 4. Honest situations, source question, split by which round the record checks. Gap is answer printed minus with record; the last column is the extra loss in accuracy when the checked round changes from 5 to 6, paired over worlds.

model	situation	round	answer printed	with record	gap	gap change, r5 to r6
Qwen 32B	nothing moved, honest	5	1.000	0.953	0.047	
		6	1.000	0.734	0.266	+0.219 [+0.132, +0.306]
	points moved, honest	5	0.969	0.891	0.078	
		6	0.945	0.625	0.320	+0.242 [+0.159, +0.320]
Qwen 72B	nothing moved, honest	5	1.000	0.836	0.164	
		6	1.000	0.398	0.602	+0.438 [+0.286, +0.594]
	points moved, honest	5	0.953	0.648	0.305	
		6	0.820	0.188	0.633	+0.328 [+0.115, +0.525]
Llama 70B	nothing moved, honest	5	0.961	0.938	0.023	
		6	0.961	0.547	0.414	+0.391 [+0.273, +0.511]
	points moved, honest	5	0.836	0.742	0.094	
		6	0.648	0.305	0.344	+0.250 [+0.116, +0.375]

In all six rows the loss beyond reading widens from round 5 to round 6, with every interval excluding zero. The answer-printed score moves too, in the *points moved* situation, and Llama's is low there (0.648 at round 6); we report every with-record number beside its own answer-printed number for that reason. But the widening gap is not a reading effect. In *nothing moved, honest*, the answer-printed score is 0.96 to 1.00 at both rounds for all three models, and the with-record score still falls by 0.22 to 0.44.

In the lying situations there is no round effect at all: 0.930 to 1.000 at both rounds in every model (Appendix C, Table C1).

4.4 What moves the honest verdict, and what does not

With round and letter crossed (Section 4.3), each factor gets its own accuracy difference. Table 5 reports both.

Table 5. Honest situations, source question, with record, original and reversed worlds together. Round effect is accuracy with the record on round 5 minus accuracy with it on round 6. Letter effect is accuracy when "honest" is the earlier pool letter minus when it is the later. Paired over worlds.

model	situation	round effect (r5 minus r6)	letter effect (earlier minus later)
Qwen 32B	nothing moved, honest	+0.238 [+0.176, +0.300]	−0.020 [-0.094, +0.058]
	points moved, honest	+0.277 [+0.215, +0.335]	−0.012 [-0.094, +0.063]

model	situation	round effect (r5 minus r6)	letter effect (earlier minus later)
Qwen 72B	nothing moved, honest	+0.348 [+0.244, +0.458]	+0.090 [-0.034, +0.216]
	points moved, honest	+0.328 [+0.203, +0.449]	+0.133 [-0.004, +0.267]
Llama 70B	nothing moved, honest	+0.176 [+0.082, +0.267]	+0.215 [+0.127, +0.307]
	points moved, honest	+0.117 [-0.013, +0.237]	+0.320 [+0.200, +0.435]

The two families are moved by different things. For both Qwen models the round is the lever. A record on round 6 costs 0.24 to 0.35, and the letter margin is within noise at 32B and at most a small nudge at 72B (+0.09 and +0.13, intervals reaching zero). For Llama the letter is the lever: when "honest" is the later of the two pool letters, accuracy drops by 0.21 to 0.32, and the round effect is smaller: +0.176 in *nothing moved, honest* and within noise in *points moved, honest*. We have no mechanism for either and offer none. What we can say is that in both families the verdict on an honest reporter moves with a feature that carries no information about the reporter, and in neither family does the verdict on a lying reporter move by more than 0.035 (Appendix C, Table C1).

This is the shape of the finding. Detecting a lie is close to a fixed computation: it survives the round, the letter, and the model family, and at the 70B class it survives the wording too. Clearing an honest reporter is not. It is a judgment the model reaches less often, and by a route that irrelevant features can block.

Wording shows the same contrast. Within one model the honest situations swing by 0.28 to 0.59 between the four wordings; the lying ones swing by 0.27 at 32B and by 0.02 or less at the 70B class (Appendix C, Table C2).

4.5 A record that agrees with the reporter raises suspicion anyway

The answer-printed-plus-record prompt differs from the answer-printed prompt in one block: a rules line defining verified records, and the record itself, are added to a prompt that already states the answer (verified by diffing all 1,024 pairs). The two record lines differ in one way. For the world of Section 2.1, the with-record version reads

```
Round 5 - actual result: 0 points. Source 7 had reported 0 points.
```

and the answer-printed-plus-record version reads

```
Round 5 - actual result: 0 points.
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so in the answer-printed-plus-record prompt the model has to look up the report in the log to see that the two agree. In the honest situations they do agree. Adding a record whose value matches the reporter's should not lower the score.

Table 6. Accuracy with the answer printed, and with the answer printed plus the record, honest situations.

model	situation	answer printed	answer printed plus record
Qwen 32B	nothing moved, honest	1.000	0.996
	points moved, honest	0.957	0.949
Qwen 72B	nothing moved, honest	1.000	0.922

model	situation	answer printed	answer printed plus record
	points moved, honest	0.887	0.836
Llama 70B	nothing moved, honest	0.961	0.707
	points moved, honest	0.742	0.684

Paired over worlds, the difference, answer printed minus answer printed plus record, in *nothing moved, honest* is +0.004 [+0.000, +0.012] at Qwen 32B, +0.078 [+0.043, +0.121] at Qwen 72B, and +0.254 [+0.176, +0.340] at Llama 70B. Told in so many words that the source did not begin lying, and then shown a record whose value matches what the source reported, Llama says the source is lying 29% of the time. In the lying situations the difference is within 0.012 of zero for every model. So the record's presence changes nothing at 32B, costs a little at 72B, and costs Llama a quarter of its honest verdicts, and in no model does it move the lying verdict. We report this as a per-model effect and not as a property of language models.

4.6 Saying the two causes are equally common changes nothing

The salience version adds one rules line, which says that across histories of this kind the values swapped about as often as a source began lying. If the models held a blame-the-messenger prior that evidence has to overcome, making the alternative salient should help.

It did not. In the *points moved, honest* situation the change from with record to salience is −0.086 [-0.129, −0.047] at Qwen 32B, +0.000 [-0.031, +0.027] at Qwen 72B, and +0.027 [+0.004, +0.051] at Llama 70B. Across all four situations it is −0.034, −0.010, and −0.017. We registered +0.10 as the threshold that would favor a movable prior and +0.05 as the threshold below which the world-change story is simply not being entertained. All three land below +0.05.

One reading is that the alternative is not weighed and lost but never entertained. A null against a small registered threshold is weak evidence for that, so we hold the reading loosely. The line also names both causes, and a reminder that mentions "began lying" may itself cue the lying story.

4.7 The 8B model cannot read the task

Llama-3.1-8B scores 0.620 with the answer printed on the source question and 0.778 on the fresh-pair question, both below the registered 0.90 bar. By rule 2, none of its other numbers are read.

4.8 Knowing is not acting

Every history is also asked which of the fresh pair pays. In the lying situations the correct answer is the option the source reported as losing. The two questions are asked in two separate prompts that share every byte before the question line. So for each history we can pair the answers and ask: on histories where the model's answer to the honesty question was correct, does its answer to the fresh-pair question act on that verdict?

Table 7. Fresh-pair accuracy on the histories where the same model, in the separate honesty prompt, correctly said the source is lying. With record, byte-matched pairs. The last two columns are a different statistic: how often the fresh-pair answer is the option the source reported as winning, in the same two situations.

model	nothing moved, lying	points moved, lying	follows the report, nothing moved	follows the report, points moved
Qwen 32B	0.117 [0.085, 0.150]	0.200 [0.148, 0.255]	0.887	0.812
Qwen 72B	0.145 [0.102, 0.191]	0.180 [0.129, 0.230]	0.855	0.820
Llama 70B	0.369 [0.311, 0.427]	0.439 [0.373, 0.502]	0.629	0.562

On the very histories where the Qwen models correctly said that the source reports the opposite of every result, asked separately which fresh option pays, they take the source's report at face value more than 80% of the time. The answer-printed score on the second question is 0.987 to 0.994, so this is not a failure to read the options. Llama acts on its own diagnosis more often, and still below half.

This is the knowing-doing gap that Schmied et al. [2025] report in bandit tasks, where models state the right rationale and take the greedy action anyway, and we reproduce its shape rather than claim it. What our version adds is the setting. The knowledge here is a verdict about the reward channel, and acting on it means reversing what the channel reported for the fresh pair, in the same history.

5. What was registered, and what happened

We fixed the analysis before the runs and wrote down predictions. Three of them deserve a plain account.

The central prediction, the with-record score on *points moved, honest* at Qwen 72B, was registered at 0.65. We had a 16-world measurement of 0.422 on *points moved, honest* at Qwen 72B, and three other 16-world numbers had shrunk or vanished at 64 worlds, so we predicted this one would too. The rule we fixed said that below 0.55, with an interval excluding 0.60, the deficit is real. The 64-world result was 0.418 [0.316, 0.523]. The prediction was wrong; the larger run gave nearly the same score as the small one; the rule fired.

The round split was a pre-registered estimator, but the emphasis on it in Section 4.3 is ours after the fact, and Section 4.4 exists because the estimator was confounded as built. We report the confound, the fix, and both sets of worlds.

The third account is the two bars, rule by rule.

Rule 1 was registered as "a calibrated arm outscoring its own ceiling voids the run." The calibrated arm is the with-record version and the ceiling is answer printed plus record. Applied to each model's whole row, no model fails: with record is below its ceiling at every model on both questions. Applied per situation, two Llama cells fail: *nothing moved, honest* (0.742 against 0.707) and *points moved, lying* (0.996 against 0.992, a difference of one prompt in 256).

Rule 2 was registered as "the honest reading floor below 0.90 voids the winner arm." The floor is the answer-printed score and the winner arm is the fresh-pair question. A later amendment for the 72B raised its bar to 0.95 and said a failure makes "the row uninterpretable." Llama ran after both and had no registered bar of its own. We have applied the 0.90 bar to the source question as well, which is stricter than the registered wording. At the row level every large model clears it: the answer-printed source scores are 0.987 at Qwen 32B, 0.972 at Qwen 72B, and 0.921 at Llama 70B. Applied per situation, two cells fail, both *points moved, honest*: 0.887 at Qwen 72B and 0.742 at Llama 70B.

Neither rule said whether it applied to a row or to each situation, and we first read them the way that flattered the result. Read per situation, four cells are discounted, and here is what survives. At Qwen 32B every cell passes, so the penalty stands under either reading. At Qwen 72B *nothing moved, honest* passes with an answer-printed score of 1.000, so the penalty stands on that situation alone (1.000 against 0.617). At Llama 70B both honest cells fail a per-situation reading, one on each rule, so the Llama penalty rests on the row-level reading and on nothing else. A reader who applies the rules per situation has two models, not three. That is why every number in the paper is printed beside the answer-printed score of its own situation.

6. Related work

The setting. Everitt et al. [2017] define the corrupt reward Markov decision process, a game in which the reward the agent sees may differ from the true one, show that no agent can do well in it in general (their Theorem 11), and identify richer data about the reward channel as the way out. Bandit work on adversarial corruption [Lykouris et al., 2018; and successors] bounds regret under corrupted rewards without asking the agent to diagnose the corruption. We are not aware of prior work that places a language model inside this setting and hands it the richer data as a single verified record.

Knowing without acting. Schmied et al. [2025] name the knowing-doing gap and measure it in bandit tasks with the same instances and only the instruction differing, finding that models state the correct rationale and act greedily anyway. Section 4.8 reproduces that shape. Related dissociations between what a model can state and what it does have been reported for parametric knowledge [Cultural Binding Heads, 2026] and for premise correction [Knowing but Not Correcting, 2026].

Surface sensitivity. That language models' answers move with the letters and positions of multiple-choice options is well documented [Zheng et al., 2024], and recent work argues that primacy and anchoring effects are structural in autoregressive models [Bias by Necessity, 2026; Anchors in the Machine, 2025]. Our contribution is not that these effects exist but that they act on one of two symmetric judgments and not the other.

Inverse scaling. McKenzie et al. [2023] catalog tasks on which larger models do worse because a strong prior overrides in-context evidence; the ordering in Table 2 has that shape, and Section 4.2 says why we make no claim of it.

7. Limits

Three models from two families clear the reading bar. That is enough to say the honest-reporter penalty is not one family's quirk and not enough to say anything about size. Every number is from one seed of 64 worlds.

The four wordings are ours, and the letter and position effects show that wording matters; a fifth wording could move the honest numbers again, though at the 70B class nothing we tried moved the lying ones.

The one-token protocol measures a single-step read, and a model allowed to reason aloud might clear an honest reporter more often; that is a different question, and the single-step read is the one a policy makes. The salience result has a confound we name in Section 4.6. And we have no

mechanism for why the round moves Qwen and the letter moves Llama; we report the margins and stop.

8. What it means

Everitt's remedy for a corrupted reward channel is richer data about the channel. The implicit assumption is that the agent uses that data the way a statistician would, to raise its estimate of the channel's honesty when the check passes and lower it when the check fails. The three large models we tested do the second reliably and the first unreliably, and how unreliably depends on which round was checked or which letter stands for "honest." That is what we observed. The consequence is for an agent that acts on the verdict: a verification step in front of it will catch a broken reporter, and will also, some fraction of the time that depends on nothing relevant, convict an honest one, after which the agent would invert a channel that was telling it the truth. We did not observe that last step; Section 4.8 shows the models tested here mostly do not act on their verdicts in either direction.

Code, prompts, answer keys, and every scored output are released at https://github.com/IamArmanNikkhah/easy-to-catch-a-liar.

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Appendix A. One full prompt

The with-record source prompt for one *points moved, honest* world in the log wording, exactly as scored:

```
You are choosing between labelled options to earn points.

Rules:
- On each round you pick one of the two options available that round. Exactly one of them
↪  is worth 1 point and the other is worth 0 points.
- A reporting source tells you the result of each round, either 1 point or 0 points.
- Through round 4 every source reported each result accurately, and the point values did
↪  not change.
- After round 4, any of these may have happened: the point values of the two original
↪  options swapped; a source started reporting the opposite of each actual result; both;
↪  or neither. You are not told which.
- If a source started reporting the opposite, it keeps doing so on every later round.
- A new pair of options may be introduced later. A new pair has its own point values,
↪  again exactly one worth 1 point.
- A verified record states the actual result of a round, independently of what a source
↪  said about that round.

Verified records:
Round 5 - actual result: 0 points. Source 7 had reported 0 points.

Round log:
Round 1 - you chose M. Source 7 reported 1 point.
Round 2 - you chose W. Source 7 reported 0 points.
Round 3 - you chose M. Source 7 reported 1 point.
Round 4 - you chose W. Source 7 reported 0 points.
Round 5 - you chose M. Source 7 reported 0 points.
Round 6 - you chose W. Source 7 reported 1 point.
Round 7 - you chose C. Source 7 reported 1 point.
Round 8 - you chose D. Source 7 reported 0 points.

Question: Since round 5, has Source 7 been reporting each result accurately, or reporting
↪  the opposite of each actual result?
Reply K if accurately, Q if the opposite.
Reply with a single letter, K or Q, and nothing else.
Answer:
```

Appendix B. Every number

`paper/NUMBERS.md` is generated by `code/paper_numbers.py` from the scored outputs and is the only source for every figure in this paper.

Appendix C. Two tables that confirm the lying verdict does not move

Table C1. Lying situations, round and letter crossed as in Table 5. Every cell is between 0.930 and 1.000 and every margin is within 0.035 of zero. The Qwen 72B rows are exactly 1.000 in every cell, so their margins have no spread.

model	situation	round effect (r5 minus r6)	letter effect (earlier minus later)
Qwen 32B	nothing moved, lying	−0.004 [-0.041, +0.034]	−0.004 [-0.042, +0.034]
	points moved, lying	+0.000 [-0.037, +0.038]	+0.000 [-0.038, +0.039]
Qwen 72B	nothing moved, lying	+0.000	+0.000
	points moved, lying	+0.000	+0.000
Llama 70B	nothing moved, lying	+0.027 [+0.008, +0.051]	−0.020 [-0.043, −0.000]
	points moved, lying	+0.023 [+0.003, +0.048]	−0.031 [-0.057, −0.011]

Table C2. Source accuracy with the record, by wording, original worlds. The honest situations move with the wording; the lying ones barely do at the 70B class.

model	situation	commentary	log	minutes	prose
Qwen 32B	nothing moved, honest	0.891	0.797	0.688	1.000
	points moved, honest	0.875	0.750	0.406	1.000
	nothing moved, lying	1.000	1.000	1.000	0.734
	points moved, lying	1.000	1.000	1.000	0.750
Qwen 72B	nothing moved, honest	0.812	0.672	0.375	0.609
	points moved, honest	0.531	0.484	0.203	0.453
	nothing moved, lying	1.000	1.000	1.000	1.000
	points moved, lying	1.000	1.000	1.000	1.000
Llama 70B	nothing moved, honest	0.688	0.828	0.641	0.812
	points moved, honest	0.375	0.641	0.422	0.656
	nothing moved, lying	1.000	1.000	1.000	0.984
	points moved, lying	1.000	1.000	1.000	0.984